

EDUCATION

University of California Berkeley | *PhD. Environmental Science, Policy, and Management* | 2026 - Present
University of California Santa Barbara | *B.A. Marine Science* | 2021-2025 | GPA: 3.96 | Highest Honors, Top 2.5%

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Paua Marine Research Group: Long Beach, CA

Dive and Research Technician (January 2026 - August 2026)

- Assist the diving and data analysis objectives of eelgrass and abalone restoration

Bren School of Environmental Science & Management: Santa Barbara, CA

Researcher (January 2025 - Present)

- Compile fin measurements for 522 shark species to design finning vulnerability models

UCSB Ocean Recoveries Lab: Santa Barbara, CA

Undergraduate Researcher (January 2022 - Present)

- Led a project to characterize predation on coral reefs in French Polynesia
- Led a project to study the effect of fish-coral mutualisms on coral physiology in French Polynesia
- Led a project to predict ecosystem functions of California seaweeds using herbarium specimens

Bren School of Environmental Science & Management: Santa Barbara, CA

Data Research and Communication Outreach Intern (June 2022 - September 2022)

- Mapped whale entanglements and potential fishing exclusion zones in California
- Drafted media and communication materials to inform non-profits about marine debris

UCSB Cheadle Center for Biodiversity and Ecological Restoration: Santa Barbara, CA

Student Coordinator (August 2021 - March 2023)

- Trained and supervised volunteer invertebrate monitoring in Devereaux Slough
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PUBLICATIONS

Vega, H., Osenberg, C., Seifert, A., Munk, N., Stier, A. Coral-associated fishes accelerate coral wound healing and photosynthetic recovery. *Biol Lett* 1 July 2026; 22 (7): 20260177. <https://doi.org/10.1098/rsbl.2026.0177>

Vega, H., et al. (2026). Supplementary material from "Coral-associated fishes accelerate coral wound healing and photosynthetic recovery". The Royal Society. Collection. <https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.c.8531212.v1>

Vega, H., Stier, A. (2026) Data and Analyses for Coral-Associated Fishes Accelerate Coral Wound Healing and Photosynthetic Recovery [Repository] <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20361854>

Vega, H., & Feitosa, L. M. (2026). *Fin Atlas, a comprehensive dataset of shark fin morphometrics for conservation and eco-evolutionary analyses* (Version 1.0) [Computer software]. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19334680>

Vega, H., & Feitosa, L. M. (2025). *Fin Atlas, a comprehensive dataset of shark fin morphometrics for conservation and eco-evolutionary analyses*. (Version 1.0) [Dataset]. <https://doi.org/10.5061/dryad.7h44j1081>

(Under Peer Review) Vega, H., & Feitosa, L. M. (2026). *Fin Atlas, a comprehensive dataset of shark fin morphometrics for conservation and eco-evolutionary analyses* [Scientific Data]

PRESENTATIONS

Vega H. (2025). *Fish are friends and so are you!* Worster Symposium, Goleta, CA.

- Fifteen minute talk on work funded by the Worster Foundation and its impact on DEIJ

Vega H. (2025). *Coral-Associated Fishes Accelerate Coral Wound Healing and Photosynthetic Recovery*. UCSB Undergraduate Research Symposium, Goleta, CA.

- Fifteen minute talk on the role of coral-associated fish in coral lesion healing and recovery

Vega H. (2024). *Coral-Associated Fishes Accelerate Tissue Regeneration and Photosynthesis*. Western Society of Naturalists Conference, Portland, OR

- Fifteen minute talk on the role of coral-associated fishes in coral lesion healing and recovery

Vega H. (2022). *Approaches to DEIJ in environmental science*. Bren Mantell Symposium, Goleta, CA

- Panelist speaker about BIPOC experience and outreach in marine and environmental science

Vega H. (2022). *A Whale of a Problem: Mapping Fishing Debris*. Bren Mantell Symposium, Goleta, CA

- Poster on the locations of Southern California whale entanglements and marine debris

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Marine Science Department, College of Creative Studies: Santa Barbara, CA

Teaching Assistant: MARINCS 101 (January 2025 - June 2025)

- Assist instruction of an introductory data science course in R

MEDIA & OUTREACH

Featured, [Damselfish-assisted Repair of Wounded Corals Surprises Scientists](#), *Mongabay*, 2026

Photographer, [Cover Image](#), *Biology Letters*, Volume 22, Issue 8, 2026

Author, Featured, [Alumni Spotlight: Hayden Vega](#), *STEMSEAS Current*, 2026

Artist, [Coal Oil Point: A Seaweed Mosaic](#), *UC Reserve System*, 2025

Featured, [Real-world coral studies spark future in ocean conservation](#), *The Current*, 2025

Featured, [Hayden Vega: A First Generation, Triple Major Undergraduate](#), *UC Santa Barbara*, 2025

Featured, [Extraordinary Paths: Celebrating CCS Class of 2025](#), *UCSB Creative Studies*, 2025

Featured, [Blue Future: Citizen Science and Activism](#), *Patagonia*, 2024

Co-author, [Diving in to REEF Safe Sunscreen: Meet the Scientists](#), *Avasol*, 2023

Author, [ODA: Twenty Years of Debris Free Seas](#), *Ocean Defenders Alliance*, 2022

Author, [Safe Boating and Fishing Practices](#), *OC Coastkeeper*, 2020

Author, [How our Intern Brought Fishing Line Recycling to Seal Beach](#), *OC Coastkeeper*, 2020

FELLOWSHIPS & AWARDS

NSF Graduate Research Fellowship Program (2026)

UC Berkeley Chancellor's Fellowship (2026)

Princeton EEB Scholar (2025)

STEMSEAS Oceanographic Fellow (2025)

UCSB Environmental Studies Academic Achievement Award (2025)

Honorable Mention: Best Fifteen Minute Talk, *UC Undergraduate Research Symposium* (2025)

Arnhold Climate Collaborative Fellow (2025)

Schmidt Foundation Mentorship Award (2025)

Worster Foundation Research Grant (2024)

UCSB Career Catalyst Award (2024)

College of Creative Studies Travel Grant (2024)

UCSB Environmental Studies Research Grant (2024)

Tom Rogers Scholar (2024)

SACNAS - California Sea Grant Pathways to Inclusive Research Fellow (2023)

Shoreliner Scholar (2023)

Tom Rogers Scholar (2023)

Coastal Fund Research Grant (2023)

DIVERsity in Diving Fellow (2022)

Bentson Scholar (2022)

Bren Environmental Diversity Leaders Fellowship (2022)

FUERTE Undergraduate Fellow (2022)

Hispanic Scholarship Scholar (2021)

SERVICE

UCSB FUERTE Mentor *Santa Barbara, CA* (January 2024 - Present)

- Mentor undergraduate students from underrepresented backgrounds during field research experiences

UCSB Diversity in Diving Mentor *Santa Barbara, CA* (January 2023 - Present)

- Chaperone and support new divers as they complete their scientific diving certifications

Goleta Surfrider Foundation *Santa Barbara, CA* (October 2021 - June 2025)

- Sample and publish bacteria content of Santa Barbara beaches

Orange County Coastkeeper *Costa Mesa, CA* (August 2020 - September 2021)

- Draft blog reports about safe boating and angling practices

Seal Beach Fishing Line Recycling Program Founder, *Seal Beach, CA* (August 2020 - Present)

SKILLS

AAUS Diver, Rescue Diver, Nitrox Diver, CPR & First Aid, RStudio, ArcGIS, ImageJ, eDNA, French biliteracy